

U.S. DEPARTMENT OF AGRICULTURE

FOREST SERVICE

Aviation Contracting Industry Day

Date: May 12, 2026 **Time:** 9:00 a.m. – 4:00 p.m. **Location:** Jack's Urban Meeting Place (JUMP) 1000 W Myrtle St., Boise, ID 83702

AGENDA

9:00 – 9:20 a.m.

Welcome, Opening Remarks, and Objectives

- Introduction of Forest Service program leadership and contracting officials
- Introduction of DOI program leadership and contracting officials
- Purpose and objectives of Industry Day
- Overview of agenda, participation expectations, and engagement guidelines

9:20 – 10:00 a.m.

Session I: Extended Base Periods & Contract Stability

Topics:

- Industry support for 3–5 year base periods with options up to 10
- Importance of advance notice and transparent planning
- Impacts on financing, workforce retention, and capital investment
- Oversight expectations during extended performance periods

Discussion Points:

- Safeguards for longer contract terms
- Escalation and corrective action processes

10:00 – 10:45 a.m.

Session II: On-Ramping and Competition Dynamics

Topics:

- Small business support for on-ramping to prevent monopolization

- Incumbent concerns about mid-contract instability
- Impacts on investment, staffing, and operational planning

Discussion Points:

- Balancing fairness with contract stability
- Notification timelines and criteria

10:45 – 11:00 a.m.

Break

11:00 a.m. – 12:00 p.m.

Session III: Performance Measures for Extended Base Periods

Topics:

- Safety performance & SMS compliance
- Aircraft availability and mechanical reliability
- Staffing levels, qualifications, and turnover
- Mission execution metrics
- Maintenance program quality
- Administrative performance and financial stability indicators

Discussion Points:

- Standardizing performance metrics
- Required documentation and verification

12:00 – 1:00 p.m.

Lunch Break

1:00 – 1:50 p.m.

Session IV: USFS–DOI Contract Alignment

Topics:

- Evaluation criteria and scoring
- Contract duration and option structures

- MAP definitions and seasonal timelines
- Flight rate structures and fuel reimbursement
- Standby definitions and compensation
- Safety, training, and maintenance documentation standards
- Invoicing, payment timelines, and administrative processes

Discussion Points:

- Priority areas for alignment
- Mission-specific differences that must remain

1:50 – 2:30 p.m.

Session V: Evaluation Methods (LPTA, HTR-FRP, and Alternatives)

Topics:

- Concerns about subjectivity in HTR-FRP
- Risks of LPTA driving unsustainable pricing
- Preference for objective, mission-critical evaluation criteria
- Importance of past performance, safety, and reliability

Discussion Points:

- Evaluation factors that best reflect wildfire mission effectiveness
- Avoiding incentives for discretionary spending unrelated to mission outcomes

2:30 – 2:45 p.m.

Break

2:45 – 3:30 p.m.

Session VI: Economic Price Adjustments (EPA) & Rising Cost Pressures

Topics:

- Labor shortages and wage escalation
- Parts inflation (e.g., Bell +5–7% annually)
- Insurance increases (+52% over 7 years)

- Lodging and per diem increases
- Rolling stock and regulatory compliance costs

Industry Recommendations:

- Use standardized indices (BLS, OEM data)
- Avoid caps on adjustments
- Ensure independent oversight

Discussion Points:

- EPA structures that ensure fairness and sustainability
- Documentation and verification requirements

3:30 – 4:00 p.m.

Session VII: Small Business Participation & Industry Stability

Topics:

- Strong support for maintaining and expanding set-asides
- Importance of small operators for surge capacity and geographic coverage
- Risks of market consolidation
- Support for broad use of partial set-asides

Discussion Points:

- Evolving set-aside structures to support stability and competition
- Mechanisms to ensure long-term small business viability

4:00 p.m.

Closing Remarks & Next Steps

- Summary of key takeaways
- Planned timelines for acquisition updates
- Opportunities for continued engagement
- Closing from Forest Service leadership